

corporate management pyramid or make him rich overnight. I do, however, steadfastly maintain that few—if any—people who insist on squeezing themselves into stereotyped molds will ever get very far on the road to success.

I find it disheartening that so many young businessmen today conform blindly and rigidly to patterns they believe some nebulous majority has decreed are prerequisites for approval by society and for success in business. In this, they fall prey to a fundamental fallacy: the notion that the majority is automatically and invariably right. Such is hardly the case. The majority is by no means omniscient just because it is the majority. In fact, I've found that the line which divides majority opinion from mass hysteria is often so fine as to be virtually invisible. This holds as true in business as it does in any other aspect of human activity.

That the majority of businessmen think this or that, does not necessarily guarantee the validity of their opinions. The majority often has a tendency to plod slowly or to mill around helplessly. The nonconformist businessman who follows his own counsel, ignoring the cries of the pack, often reaps fantastic rewards. There are classic examples galore—some of the most dramatic ones dating from the Depression.

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The Rockefellers began building Rockefeller Center, the largest privately-owned business and entertainment complex in the United States—and possibly the entire world—in 1931, during the depths of the Depression. Most American businessmen considered the project an insane one. They conformed to the prevailing opinion which held that the nation's economy was in ruins and prophesied that the giant skyscrapers would remain untenanted shells for decades. "Rockefeller Center will be the world's biggest White Elephant," they predicted. "The Rockefellers are throwing their money down a bottomless drain."

Nonetheless, the Rockefellers went ahead with their plans and built the great Center. They reaped large profits from the project—and proved that they were right, and that the majority was dead wrong.